

E1 Shared Struggles

Formerly: "And You Thought YOUR Day Was Bad." Rebuilt from scratch. The original had a creative title but no substance.

Pillar	Enablement	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	30-40 minutes	Group Size	4-10
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	None	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Frustration signals, feeling unsupported, lack of empathy between roles, silos within the team, people not understanding each other's pressures

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

The brain processes isolation and lack of understanding through the same pain circuits as physical injury. When someone feels that their struggles are invisible to their colleagues, cortisol remains elevated and oxytocin (connection, trust) stays suppressed. The result is quiet withdrawal: people stop raising problems, stop asking for help, and stop investing emotionally in the team.

Sharing struggles in a structured, non-advice-giving format activates mirror neuron systems in listeners, building empathy. It also activates the labelling effect in the speaker: naming a struggle reduces the amygdala's threat response to it. The exercise does not solve the struggles. It makes them visible, which changes how the team relates to each other.

IF A TEAM MEMBER ASKS "WHY ARE WE DOING THIS?"

"We all deal with friction in our work that nobody else sees. This exercise makes those invisible struggles visible so we can understand what each other is actually dealing with. The rule: we listen. We don't fix. We just see each other more clearly."

The Exercise

Phase 1: Prompt Cards (5 minutes)

Prepare 8-10 prompt cards in advance. Each card describes a type of work struggle. Examples:

- "A moment this month where you felt stuck and didn't know who to ask for help"
- "The part of your job that takes three times longer than anyone realises"
- "A tool, process, or system that makes your work harder than it should be"

- "Something you've stopped raising because you don't think it will change"
- "The invisible work you do that nobody on the team knows about"

Each person draws a card. They have 2 minutes to think privately about a specific example from their own experience.

Phase 2: Sharing Round (15-20 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"The rules are simple. Share your struggle, keep it to 2 minutes, be as specific as you're comfortable with. Everyone else: just listen. No solutions, no 'have you tried...', no minimising. Just hear it. We'll come back to the practical stuff afterward."

Manager goes first to model the tone. After each share, the only response from the manager: "Thank you. That's useful to know." No more. Let the group absorb it.

Phase 3: The Enablement Question (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Now the practical part. Looking at what we've heard, which of these struggles are things we could actually fix? Not all of them. Some are just the nature of the work. But some are removable barriers. Which ones are we tolerating that we shouldn't be?"

This is where the exercise transitions from vulnerability (which belongs in V pillar exercises) to enablement: identifying and removing barriers. Capture actionable items. For each one, assign an owner and a timeline.

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
Someone shares a struggle that is clearly a management failure	Do not deflect. "I hear that, and if that's something within my control to change, I will. Give me a week to come back with a plan." Then follow through.
The sharing stays surface-level ("I have too many emails")	The prompt cards should prevent this. If it still happens, push with a follow-up: "Can you give me a specific example from this week? What happened and what was the impact on your work?"
Someone uses the exercise to vent about a specific person	Redirect to systems: "Let's keep the focus on the friction in the work rather than specific people. What about the process or structure created that situation?"

Signs This Is Working

Timeframe	What to Look For
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During the session	Shares are specific and honest At least one person says "I had no idea you dealt with that" The enablement question produces actionable items, not just sympathy
Within 2-4 weeks	At least one barrier identified in the session has been removed or reduced A team member proactively offers help to a colleague based on what they learned about their struggles Someone raises a barrier earlier than they would have before the exercise
CLOVER ERA data (4-6 weeks)	Enablement scores increase Qualitative data references feeling supported or understood Communication scores may also improve (shared understanding enables better communication)

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
V1: Vulnerability Circle	E1 has a vulnerability component but pivots to practical barrier removal. V1 stays with the emotional sharing.	Run V1 before E1 for low-trust teams
E9: Removing Outdated Processes	E1 surfaces process barriers. E9 provides the framework for removing them.	E1 feeds into E9
E5: Access to Technology	E1 often surfaces tool and technology barriers that E5 addresses systematically.	E1 feeds into E5